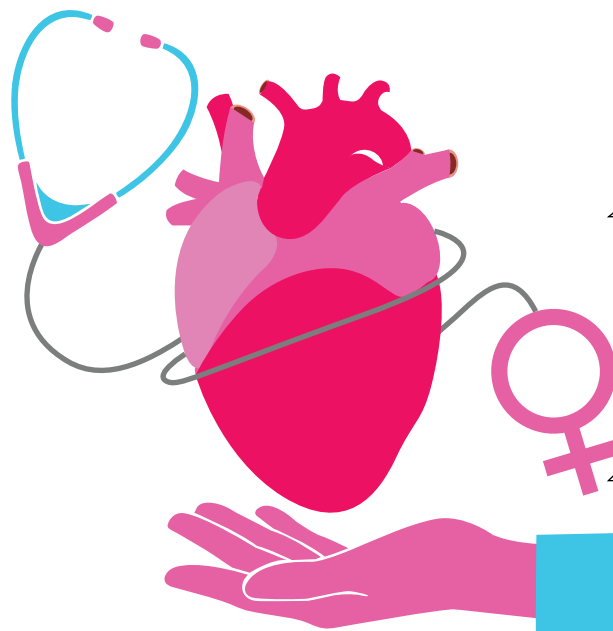


The Health Story: What the Numbers Say

ONLY **25%** OF SENIOR HEALTH ROLES ARE HELD BY WOMEN (WHO 2024)

WOMEN FORM **67%** OF THE GLOBAL HEALTH WORKFORCE (WHO 2024)

WOMEN HOLD **18%** OF SENIOR HEALTH LEADERSHIP IN INDIA (DASRA 2023)



19.5% OF MAJOR MEDICAL BODIES IN INDIA ARE LED BY WOMEN (PLOS 2024)

WOMEN MAKE UP **41%** OF HOSPITAL AND LAB WORKFORCE (UDAITI 2024)

72 | need are—think bigger, make bold decisions and become comfortable with taking big risks,” she says. She adds that pairing these attributes with care, patience, professional skills and technological fluency will become increasingly important as healthcare becomes more data driven.

Exposure to P&L, capital projects, export-market leadership and business development can be the turning point for many careers. “Women may excel in functional roles but may not be rotated into export-market leadership, large capex projects or global P&L ownership,” says Wagh of Supriya Lifescience. Such rotations, she believes, determine who enters the shortlist for top roles.

Timing also affects career trajectories. The highest attrition occurs between mid-management and senior roles, a period when women have a lot of caregiving responsibilities. “The pipeline often breaks for women around key life stages such as post-childbearing,” says Mehdwan.

WHAT NEXT

Women leaders in the sector say progress is accelerating and the next decade will be defined by widening access, stronger institutional support and the leadership women are bringing to the field. India’s hospital and healthcare delivery market is pegged at \$180 billion, the pharmaceutical industry at \$63 billion, and diagnostics market at \$11.38 billion. As they grow over the years, the opportunities for women to shape policy, clinical models, digital care and regulated manufacturing will grow correspondingly.

Women are already influencing patient-centred care models, digital platforms, compliance frameworks and workforce culture. Shah points to governance spaces and industry bodies where women are shaping national health priorities. Wagh highlights regulated-market strategies, therapeutic innovation and contract manufacturing as areas where women with strong cross-functional experience are assuming bigger roles. Kamineni believes the next leap will come from women entering data science, technology and digital care on a much larger scale.

But a significant intellectual gap remains in how female health needs are researched and funded. Jahnvi Phalkey, founder and Director of Science Gallery Bengaluru, argues that women should lead research on the female life course, from hormonal transitions to conditions such as endometriosis. “We need a better understanding of women’s health concerns,” she says.

Women leaders agree that strengthening the leadership pipeline now depends on widening pathways to commercial roles, ensuring early exposure to strategic decision-making and building organisational cultures that recognise life-course realities. As Mehdwan puts it, “Healthcare must consciously create conditions for their growth.” Women power India’s health system every day; the opportunity ahead is to match that presence with leadership. **BT**

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